City Birds Fly Away Sooner From Women

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Here is a bird mystery! City birds seem to fly away sooner when a woman walks toward them than when a man does.

Scientists tested this in parks in five **European** countries: Czechia, France, Germany, Poland and Spain. Men and women of about the same height, wearing similar clothes, walked toward birds. The scientists measured how close each person got before the bird flew off.

Men could get about one meter closer than women. This happened in every country and with all 37 kinds of birds, including **sparrows**, blackbirds, **magpies** and pigeons.

Nobody knows why yet. Birds might notice smells, body shapes or the way people walk. "I can't explain them right now," said **Professor** Daniel Blumstein, one of the scientists.

The researchers say more studies are needed. For now, it seems city birds notice things about people that we hardly notice ourselves.

Word Treasure

European -- From Europe, the continent with countries like France and Spain.

sparrows -- Small brown birds often seen in cities.

magpies -- Black-and-white birds known for being clever.

Professor -- A teacher and researcher at a university.

Background you need

Wild birds are always watching for danger and fly away when something seems risky.

Scientists measure how close a person can get before a bird flies off to learn how animals see people.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists and city birds like sparrows and pigeons
WHAT: Birds flew away sooner when women walked toward them
WHERE: Parks in five European countries
WHY: Nobody knows yet; birds might notice smells, shapes or walking

Why it matters

Next time you feed the ducks or watch pigeons, remember birds may notice more about you than you think.

Test what you remember

1. What did scientists find about city birds?

- (A) They fly away sooner from women
- (B) They only like children
- (C) They sing for men
- (D) They never fly away

2. How many countries were in the study?

- (A) Two hundred
- (B) One
- (C) Five
- (D) Fifty

3. How much closer could men get than women?

- (A) About ten meters
- (B) About one kilometer
- (C) About one meter
- (D) No closer

4. Which bird was part of the study?

- (A) Ostriches
- (B) Pigeons
- (C) Parrots
- (D) Penguins

5. Do scientists know why this happens?

- (A) No, not yet
- (B) Yes, it's the hats
- (C) Yes, it's the shoes
- (D) Yes, it's the weather

6. What is one guess about what birds notice?

- (A) People's names
- (B) Music
- (C) Phone numbers
- (D) The way people walk

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Professor Daniel Blumstein: Believes the results but can't explain them yet.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):